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Reflection Essay 1

Flock cameras are automatic license plate readers (ALPRs) that can identify vehicles using license plates and other data points, allowing them to track a vehicle's movement through a network of connected cameras (Brewster). They are currently facing significant criticism due to their potential for abuse and the way they trade personal privacy for increased safety and security. Mass surveillance technologies like Flock cameras are best understood through the lens of co-constructivism because their development and use are actively shaped by social and political decisions, while at the same time reshaping societal expectations around policing, privacy, and public safety.

First, the development and use of Flock cameras are shaped by social, political, and legal decisions, rather than being determined by the technology itself. Although these systems enable large-scale surveillance, their adoption is not inevitable, as communities and governments are actively deciding whether and how they are implemented. For example, several U.S. cities have paused or rejected Flock camera programs following public outcry over privacy concerns; while others have imposed restrictions on how long data can be stored or who it can be shared with (Chidi), and these responses show that society is still pushing back against the spread of surveillance technology, rather than passively accepting it. This shows

that the spread of surveillance is still being negotiated, not just driven by the existence of the technology. Because of this, Flock cameras have not yet reached technological lock-in, where the system is so ingrained in society it becomes challenging to remove. Instead, the ongoing resistance is disrupting the technology's momentum and preventing it from reaching that lock-in state. This supports the co-constructivism perspective, as it shows that social values and political decisions continue to shape how this technology is being developed and used.

At the same time, Flock cameras also reshape society by influencing how people understand policing, privacy, and public safety. As these systems become more common, they encourage a model of policing that prioritizes constant monitoring and rapid data analysis, which can shift public expectations toward valuing efficiency over civil liberties (Einbinder). For instance, Flock cameras are now used by thousands of law enforcement agencies, allowing police to track vehicles over large areas in a matter of minutes, which strengthens the belief that crimes can and should be solved quickly using surveillance data. Additionally, in some communities, residents have proposed using surveillance to create so-called "virtual gated communities" (Chidi), where surveillance is used to monitor and control who enters and exits certain areas. These developments show that technology doesn't just respond to societal needs, it actively reshapes them by normalizing constant surveillance and redefining safety as something that is achieved through surveillance, rather than trust and community. In doing so, Flock cameras influence both behavior and societal norms, demonstrating that technology plays an active role in shaping society. This reflects the second half of the co-constructivist perspective, where technology influences society.

Mass surveillance technologies such as the Flock ALPRs are best understood through the lens of co-constructivism because they are shaped by society, while simultaneously reshaping it. As discussed, communities, governments, and activists continue to influence how these systems are implemented, demonstrating that the technology has not yet reached full lock-in and remains subject to resistance and negotiation. At the same time, growing use of these cameras is already changing how people think about policing, privacy, and public safety, normalizing surveillance and shifting expectations towards faster, data-driven enforcement. Together, these dynamics show that the relationship between technology and society is not one-directional but rather mutually influential, proving that co-constructivism is the most accurate way to understand Flock cameras.

Works Cited

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